RINCÓN RIICHI

Learn to play

RIICHI MAHJONG · STEP-BY-STEP GUIDE



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Introduction

Riichi mahjong is a game for **four players** played with **tiles**, a bit like rummy: players take turns to **draw a tile and discard another**, trying to complete their hand. Each hand scores **points** and, after several rounds, **whoever has the most points wins**.

> *If you would rather learn by playing, read "The table", "Setup" and "Your turn" and start: you can look up the rest as you go. Words with a dotted underline can be clicked: they jump to their definition in the Dictionary (pages 13 and 14).*

What you need

- **136 tiles**: 34 different kinds, 4 copies of each.
- A **compass** (the piece in the centre) and a round-wind **plate**.
- Two **dice** and colour-coded point **sticks**.
- Four players sitting around a table.

The goal

With your 13 tiles, plus the one you draw, you want to build **4 sets and 1 pair**: 14 tiles in all. When you do, **you win the hand**.

A complete hand



How a game goes

Each player draws and discards → Someone completes their hand → Points are paid with sticks → The next hand begins

The table

Almost everything happens on a shared table. This is what you will see:



1. **The walls.** The face-down tiles, in four sides of 17 stacks of two tiles. You draw from here.
2. **The compass.** The piece in the centre: it shows each seat's wind and the small numbers used with the dice.
3. **Your hand.** Your 13 tiles, standing in front of you. Only you see their faces.
4. **The ponds.** In front of each player lie their discards, face up.
5. **The drawer.** Each player keeps their point sticks there.
6. **The plate.** It shows the round wind, to the dealer's right.
7. **The dice.** Rolled at the start to decide where the wall is opened.

Seats and winds. *Each seat has a wind: East (you, the dealer), South (on your right), West (across) and North (on your left). Turns go in this order, counter-clockwise.*

Piece glossary



Tiles: are the pieces of the game, like the cards in a deck. Each has a picture: numbers 1 to 9 in three families (characters, circles and bamboo) and some special ones with letters (winds and dragons). There are 4 copies of each picture.



The wall: are the tiles nobody holds yet, laid face down in a square on the table. On your turn you take one from there, like drawing a card from the deck.



The compass: is a piece placed in the middle of the table. It shows who sits on each side (East, South, West and North) and is used to start the game.



The plate: is a small plate with a Japanese character saying which part of the game we are in (East at the start, South later). For now just locate it: we will see what it is for later.



The sticks: are the game's "money". Each stick is worth a different amount depending on its colour and its dots, and they keep track of each player's points.



The dice: are two ordinary dice. They are rolled at the start to decide which side of the table tiles begin to be dealt from.

The four seats



East you, who starts



South on your right



West across



North on your left

The tiles

There are **34 kinds** of tile and **4 copies** of each: **136** in all. Each has a face with its picture and a coloured back.

Three numbered suits

Manzu
numbers



Pinzu
circles



Souzu
bamboo



Honors: no number

Winds



East · South · West · North

Dragons



Haku (white) · Hatsu (green) · Chun (red)

Red fives

Aka



Each one is worth a bonus

*The red fives (aka) count as a normal 5, but each one in your hand adds **1 han** (a value point) when you win. They come along with the other fives, not instead of them.*

Four copies



There are four identical 5 of circles: that is how you can keep track of how many are left.

Setup

1st **Shuffle.** Put all 136 tiles face down and have the four players mix them by hand, until nobody knows where each one is.

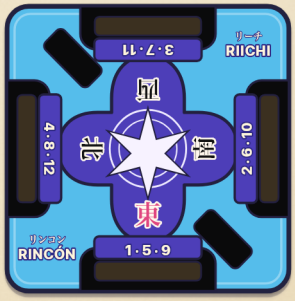
2nd **Build the walls.** Each player builds in front of them a wall of **17 stacks of two tiles** (34 tiles). Together they form a square.

3rd **Choose the dealer.** Each player rolls a die: the highest number is the **dealer**, who plays first and sits in the East seat.

4th **Place the compass.** In the centre, with each wind facing its seat, and the **round-wind plate** (East) at the edge, to the dealer's right.

5th **Open the wall.** The dealer rolls two dice. Find the total among the small numbers on the compass: it tells you **which side** to open. On that wall count as many stacks as the total and cut there.

6th **Deal.** From the cut, starting with the dealer: **4 tiles** each, three times; then **1** more each. Everyone ends with 13; the dealer draws one last tile and has 14.



The dead wall. *From the cut,* ***always 7 stacks (14 tiles)*** *are put aside: that is the dead wall, out of play except on special occasions. If the cut falls near the end of a wall, the count carries on into the next wall.*

The dora. *On the 3rd stack of the dead wall the top tile is turned face up: that is the* ***dora indicator****. The tile that follows it is worth a bonus to whoever holds it.*

Your turn

The dealer starts and the turn passes to their right, counter-clockwise. On your turn you do **three things**:

1 · You draw

You take the next tile from the wall. Now you have **14** tiles.



2 · You decide

Does it bring you closer to 4 sets and 1 pair? If not, it will be the one you discard.

3 · You discard

You leave one tile face up in your pond. You are back to **13**.



Sort your hand

Sorting lets you see your sets at a glance: keep each suit (manzu, pinzu, souzu) together and the honors together, with identical tiles side by side. You can arrange it however you like as long as it is easy to see what you have.

Example turn

Your hand has three sets, two pairs… and one loose tile, the 9 of circles. That is the one you discard.



Now you draw a Chun (中): with your two Chun it makes a triplet and the hand is complete.

*Discards are **information**: watch what the others throw to know which tiles are gone and what they are looking for.*

Sets and a complete hand

A complete hand is **4 sets and 1 pair**. There are two kinds of set.

Sequence

Three numbers **in a row from the same suit**. Winds and dragons cannot form sequences.



Triplet

Three **identical** tiles. Winds and dragons do work here.



Pair

Two identical tiles. Every complete hand has exactly one.



The count

$$4 \times 3 + 2 = 14$$

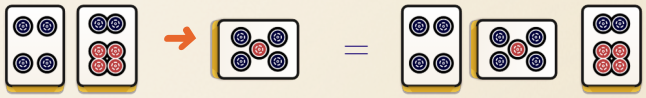
13 tiles in hand plus the one you draw: 14. The sets and the pair use all 14.

***Tenpai** means being **one tile** away from winning. **Noten** is the opposite. Both matter when the wall runs out with no winner: those in tenpai collect from the noten ones (3,000 points in total).*

Calls: chii, pon and kan

Besides drawing from the wall, you may take the tile another player has just thrown: that is called a **call**. You say the name out loud, take the tile and lay the set **face up**, with the taken tile **turned toward whoever threw it**.

Chii · a sequence



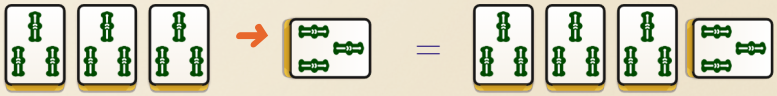
You can only take the tile from the player who plays right before you (your left), and only to make a sequence with two of your tiles.

Pon · a triplet



*With two identical tiles you can take the third one that **any** player throws. The turn jumps to you.*

Kan · a quad



With three identical tiles you take the fourth. A kan adds an extra tile: you draw a replacement from the dead wall and another dora indicator is revealed.

*Making a call turns your hand from **closed** to **open**: you can no longer declare riichi and some yaku are worth less or do not count. In return, you move faster.*

Winning: ron, tsumo and yaku

You win when you complete your hand **and** meet at least one **yaku**, a condition the hand must satisfy. There are two ways to win:

Tsumo

You win with a tile **you drew yourself**. All three rivals pay.

Ron

You win on the tile **another player threw**. Only the one who threw it pays.

When you win you say "Tsumo" or "Ron" and show your hand face up.

Three yaku to start with

Tanyao



Only tiles from 2 to 8: no honors and no ends (1 or 9).

Yakuhai



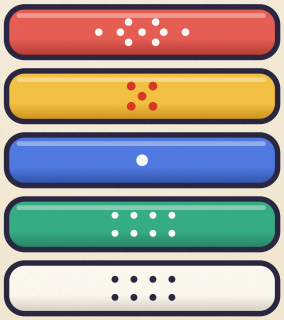
A triplet of dragons, of the round wind or of your seat wind.

Riichi. With a closed hand one tile from winning (tenpai), you may declare "Riichi": you throw the tile **lying on its side** and put a **1,000-point stick** in the compass slot. From then on you do not change your hand: you only draw and throw what you draw.

> ***Furiten.*** *If you have already thrown any of the tiles you would win on, you cannot win by ron, only by tsumo. Nobody warns you: you have to notice it yourself.*

Points and sticks

Points are kept as **colour-coded sticks**. Each stick is **worth** a fixed amount. Each player starts with 25,000 points and keeps them in their drawer.



10 000 *red*

5 000 *yellow*

1 000 *blue*

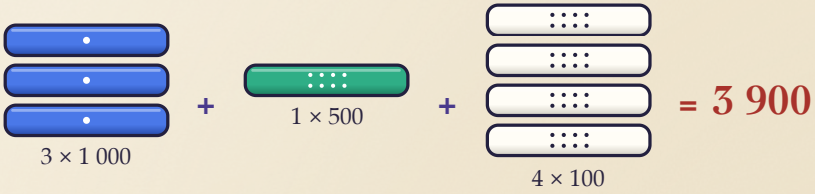
500 *green*

100 *white*

Counting the hand

When you win, the hand's value is counted with **han** (yaku and dora) and **fu** (mini points). Together they give the points; the site's scoring section has full tables.

Paying 3,900 points



*The payer leaves the sticks **on the table** and the winner **takes** them.*

- **Ron:** the one who threw the winning tile pays.
- **Tsumo:** all three rivals pay.
- The **dealer** collects and pays more than the others.

*Points decide the game: when it ends they are compared and **whoever has the most wins**.*

Rounds and the end of the game

The game is played **hand after hand**. Each hand ends when someone wins or when the wall runs out with no winner.



A **round** is four hands, one for each dealer. The plate on the edge shows the **round wind**: East first, South after.

When each hand ends

- **The dealer wins:** they stay dealer and the winds **do not change**.
- **Someone else wins (or nobody wins and the dealer is not in tenpai):** the **compass turns**: each player takes the next seat wind and the dealer passes to the player on their right.
- **A full turn:** the round moves to South and the plate is flipped.

Length of the game

Tonpuusen / Hanchan

Tonpuusen
Short game: East round only.

Hanchan
Standard game: East and South rounds.



At the end each player's sticks are counted. **Whoever has the most points wins.**

Dictionary

The words of this guide, in plain language.

Tile

Each piece of the game. There are 136: 34 different kinds with 4 copies of each.

Suit

A family of tiles numbered 1 to 9: manzu (numbers), pinzu (circles) and souzu (bamboo).

Honors

The tiles without a number: 4 winds (East, South, West, North) and 3 dragons.

Wall

The face-down tiles, set in 4 sides of 17 stacks. Every player draws from it.

Dead wall

7 stacks (14 tiles) set apart when the wall is opened. They are out of play, except on special occasions such as a kan; the dora indicator is turned there too.

Dealer

The player who plays first in the hand; they sit in the East seat. If they win, they stay dealer.

Compass

The piece in the centre of the table. It shows each seat's wind and the small numbers used with the dice.

Seat wind

The wind that belongs to your seat: East, South, West or North. It is different for each player and changes when the hand passes.

Round wind

The wind of the current round (East first, then South). It is the same for all four and the plate on the table edge shows it.

Round and hand

A hand is one deal played from start to finish. A round is four hands, one for each dealer.

Set

Three tiles that go together: a sequence (3 consecutive numbers of one suit) or a triplet (3 identical).

Pair

Two identical tiles. A complete hand has exactly one pair.

Pond

The area in front of each player where their discards lie face up.

Dora

A bonus tile: each one in your hand adds an extra han (a value point). The dora indicator shows which one.

Dictionary

Continued.

Riichi

Declaring that your hand is one tile from winning. You put a 1,000-point stick on the table and no longer change your hand.

Tsumo

Winning with a tile you drew yourself from the wall.

Ron

Winning on a tile another player threw.

Yaku

A condition your hand must meet in order to win (for example riichi, tanyao or yakuhai). Without at least one yaku you cannot win.

Tanyao

A yaku: a hand with only tiles from 2 to 8, no honors and no ends (1 or 9).

Yakuhai

A yaku: a triplet of dragons, of the round wind or of your seat wind.

Call

Taking the tile another player has just thrown to make a set: chii (sequence), pon (triplet) or kan (quad).

Open / closed hand

Closed: you made no calls. Open: you made at least one. With an open hand you cannot declare riichi.

Tenpai

Your hand is one tile away from winning.

Noten

The opposite of tenpai: your hand is not one tile from winning. It matters when the wall runs out with no winner.

Furiten

A trap: if you have already thrown one of the tiles that would let you win, you cannot win by ron (you can by tsumo).

Han and fu

The two measures used to count a winning hand: han (value of yaku and dora) and fu (mini points). Together they give the points.

Stick

Points are kept as colour-coded sticks; each stick is worth a fixed amount (100 to 10,000).

Tonpuusen and hanchan

Two game lengths: tonpuusen (East round only) and hanchan (East and South rounds). At the end, whoever has the most points wins.



Keep learning

This guide goes with the **Rincón Riichi** site. There you can see the same ideas in animations, try each step and practise with short drills.

- **Tutorial** — the table and a complete hand, step by step.
- **Tiles, wait types and yaku** — references with examples.
- **Practise** — recognise tiles, count points and more, with a quick mode.

rincon-riichi.vercel.app